"A Poor Devil."

By Winnie Eaton, Montreal.

[written for the metropolitan.]

[*Continued.*]

I relaxed my grasp, and his head fell back. He had evidently fainted. Then I rose to my feet, the bag in my hand. A struggle far worse than that I had had with the man was going on in my inmost soul—a struggle 'twixt right and wrong.

At last, at last, I held in my hand that which I wanted all my life—wealth. Should I take it—should I use it? It belonged to someone else, and I was honest—honest. I swear to you I was honest. I dropped the bag to the ground. I stood straight. I bent down and picked it up. Again and again I picked it up, again and again I threw it down. I held it in my hand again. "Oh great God, help me!" I cried. Did He hear my prayer? I flung it from me, and turned my back on it, then I felt a stealthy movement, and I looked around. A long skinny arm had grasped it. As he sprang to his feet I darted on him. The moment I saw his arm stretched for the bag I realized how much I wanted it. A second struggle commenced, and we were getting nearer and nearer to the water's edge. Suddenly he went over. There was a splash—a yell of despair—a moan, and then all was silent, and I stood alone. "Oh God in heaven, forgive me!"

I had come here contemplating crime—suicide. I had committed two—murder and robbery.

It was raining hard now, and I shivered with cold. I had only on a thin coat, three years old, and threadbare and shabby, and it was the beginning of April. I picked the bag up, and with slow, unsteady steps began retracing my way towards my home. It must then have been about 12 o'clock, for the streets were almost entirely deserted. I was not often out as late as that, and Mrs. Rawlings, my landlady, was sitting up for me. I had no latch-key, and my hands were trembling with cold and fear so much I could hardly pull the bell. Every moment I felt I must fall. It seemed an eternity before they opened the door and let me in, and then I staggered across the hall. I could hear Mrs. Rawlings' voice exclaiming something. She thought I was drunk.

"Take care of that," I cried, and threw the bag towards her. Then I fell.

For five weeks I knew no one, then at last one morning in May I returned to consciousness. I imagined I had merely awakened from a long sleep, but it was odd that Mrs. Rawlings should be sitting beside my bed. She had never done such a thing before. She was sewing and evidently had not observed my movements.

"Mrs. Rawlings," I said, "What do you want in my room?" My voice was so weak I hardly knew it.

Mrs. Rawlings dropped her work and came to me. She would not let me speak, nor answer my questions. All I could gather from her was that I had come home, had fainted in the hall, and had been sick for five weeks.

I remembered all now, and quietly I lay there and said to myself, "You are a murderer and a thief," then I remembered the bag. I would not lose that for all the world, and rose in bed, but I was very weak. "The bag" was all I could say.

"It is in the cupboard and no one has touched it."

I fell back relieved on my pillow, and did not ask for it, for I dreaded at first even to look at it.

How much planning and thinking I did during my recovery was impossible to say. I would lie for hours and dream and dream of what I should do when better; how I should spend money and revel in pleasures. Strange, but during my long illness, she never came into my thoughts.

When I was strong enough to sit up I asked Mrs. Rawlings to bring me the bag, and then leave me alone.

What was there about that small bag which made my head reel, my blood run cold? It was an ordinary little black valise. Why did I hate to look at it? Was it hate that I felt, or was it merely that I was bewildered at having at last that which I had longed for all my life. No, it was not that. There was something else. I had seen it before. There it lay at the foot of my bed, within reach of my hand. Merciful heavens! It was so familiar. Where had I seen it before, where? where?

I drew it towards me, and with a key that hung by a string from its handle, I unlocked it. It was full to the top. There were thousands of dollars there—and jewels. I was rich, rich, rich at last.

As soon as I was able to get out I called upon my late employers, and informed that I had been left some money, and was now leaving the country. I parted good friends with them all—the partners, the students, the typewritist, and the office boy. I did not trouble myself to find out what they thought of me, for I had too much else to think of.

My chief thought, my one thought now, was to find them, that old man and his daughter. They must, of course, by this time be in Europe. I had money, and I would follow them, if need be all over the world.

The next three years of my life were spent in travelling. I went to England, to France, to Italy, to Egypt. I went everywhere. I had everything that money could buy—everything now that I had told myself would make me happy—and was I happy? No. Observe, it is good to have money, it is good to be rich, it is good to be envied, to be toadied to. It is good to have all that, but it is better to be loved. It is best of all to have peace of mind, and I was haunted. Wherever I went I was haunted by three faces and a little black bag. At the hotel, when I took my meals with other men, I saw them not, for instead, I saw a small, terrified, frightened, little man, whose eyes started from their sockets, and who fell back with a wild yell. He was the man I had robbed, murdered, and it was right that I should be haunted by him; but these others, what had I ever done to them? This old man with the highbred face and contemptuous smile, and her—she looked at me with loathing and fear. Why, my God! was I haunted by them? Had I wronged her—him, in any way? I know not, only that they were with me always, everywhere, with that other one. In my cupboard stood a small brown bag. I had had it re-covered with brown, but to me it was always black, black. There was something startling in that small bag, and but to look at it made me shiver, yet I never destroyed it—I could not. It was empty, for I had taken all out, but wherever I went I took it with me, for I loved it, though I feared it. I drank, I gambled, I lived a wild life; I tried to forget—I could not.

Never once had I seen that old man and his daughter, although I made enquiries and searched all through Europe for them.

Oh, to be poor again—to have something to wish for, to long for. That is happiness. When I was poor did I not love my troubles? Did I not love to think, to brood over them?

I returned to Canada, and at last I found them—found them where I had left them, but oh how changed were the circumstances under which I found them to those in which I had left them, for they had lost everything. They were as poor now as I had been then.

Shall I tell you how I wound myself into their lives? How I humbled that proud old man, and won his consent to my marriage with her?

I lent him money. I helped him out of his difficulties. I held him in my power. How he cringed to me! How he flattered me, and yet hated me! I promised to give him all he had lost if he would give me her, and he consented—consented to give her to the man he could not but hate, and we were betrothed.

Listen! I lost wealth, I lost her, everything, in one day. I was taking him for a drive when he told me how he had lost his money, had been robbed. The day he had bidden good-bye to all in our office he had been waylaid and robbed of his valise, which contained all, as he had then said, he possessed in the world. They had intended going away the following day, and he had drawn out all his money from the banks, and had put it in that small black valise with all or most of his valuables, and he had been followed and robbed.

All was explained now. I understood why he and she had haunted me as well as that other, for I had wronged them too. That small black bag was his. All I possessed was his, and he knew it not, and that day had promised me his daughter, his only child. Well, I should repay them all back, and with interest.

How plainly that night I saw his little weezened face, heard his despairing yell. Back and forth I walked in my room. I put my hands to my ears to shut out his moans. I closed my eyes, but I saw him with my closed eyes—heard him with my closed ears. "Ah, God," I prayed, "give me another chance. I swear to you that I am not really bad—but circumstances—fate—has made me what I am."

I heard the door open, and she came in. She looked ill and in trouble, and as usual fearful of me. She spake quickly, with little gasps, as if she were trying to control herself, and not say too much.

"Father has told me what you want. I have come to give you my answer myself. It is this: No. I cannot, I will not be your wife. I have

tried to like you, but I cannot, at least not that way. Why do you torture me as you do? You know, you must know, that I am afraid of you—yet you follow me—you are near me always. My father owes you money, I know. He, he—you have got him in your power in some way, and you take advantage—you thrust yourself on me, and I—I hate you."

I was not surprised, and I laughed—hideously, loudly—bitterly. "Hate me, if you will, I love you with all my soul. I adore you."

She fell on her knees by my table, and leaning her face in her hands against it, sobbed bitterly.

"I don't hate you but, but, I can't explain myself. I am afraid of you. I don't know why, and when father said I must marry you I hated—detested you. Listen, I—I love someone else. We love one another. On please give me up; don't force me to hate you."

At these words, "I love someone else," every particle of hope I ever had had departed, and at that moment I gave her up.

"I will molest you no longer," I said. "Return to your father—but wait, I will give you something to take with you."

I wrote to him and confessed everything. I asked for no leniency to be shown to me. Nay, I begged him to punish me as severely as I deserved to be.

And now I am here, the room is small, the doors and windows iron and barred and the floors are bare. There is no bed to lie on, only a bunk with straw in it. Do you know the place; have you ever been there?

I am awaiting my trial. Well, I shall plead guilty to everything. I stole his money—I killed that man. From the four corners of my cell he stares at me. He is afraid of me, and I of him. Hush! Hark how he yells and moans!

"Oh, God, who art merciful, take this horror away from me. I have been wicked—I am a criminal, a murderer and a thief. I acknowledge my sins and I repent of them all. Hear me, oh God, pardon and pity me. Amen.

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Dim'd with a tear for happiness gone by,
Then coyly views in youth's commanding pride
Her own adored one, kneeling by her side;
Like lilies bending 'neath the noon-tide blaze,
Her bashful eyelids sink beneath his gaze,
While love and homage blend their blissful power
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What though this chance-abounding life ordain
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